

Your kid gets away with things at Grandma's that you don't allow at home

8 findings · 13-step checklist · 1 myth · 5 sources · cheatgrid.com

Children sort what's allowed by place early, without anyone explaining it, so a different rule at Grandma's doesn't undo yours at home. The sting is about her and you, not your kid.

THE GOAL

You're holding your own rule tonight without needing Grandma to enforce it for it to count. Say once, calmly, that's Grandma's house and **this is ours**.

CHECKLIST

The moment your child throws Grandma's rule back at you to get out of yours.

- ☐ Say, once and calmly: "That's Grandma's house. **This is ours**," before you explain anything else.
- ☐ Name the exact rule you're holding tonight in one sentence, like bedtime or screen time, instead of arguing about who's right.
- ☐ If your child says she's more fun, don't compete for the title. Say "Maybe. This still stands," and stop.
- ☐ Handle what's actually in front of you first: an overtired kid, a sugar crash, or a wound-up kid from extra screen time.
- ☐ Apply tonight's normal consequence for the broken rule exactly as you would any other night, with nothing extra added on.
- ☐ Ask yourself one question: **would Grandma have done what she just did with you standing right there watching?**
- ☐ If she'd do it in front of you, decide, just for tonight, whether this specific rule is even worth raising with her.
- ☐ If she'd only do it while you're not there, tell your child, calmly: "**You don't have to keep this a secret from me.**"
- ☐ If she'd only do it while you're not there, write down what happened and when, so you have it to point to later.
- ☐ If your reaction feels bigger than what's actually at stake, say the real reason out loud once, apart from tonight's rule.
- ☐ If you decide to raise a single thing with her, pick that thing and choose a calm moment later, not at pickup.
- ☐ Plan the actual line around trust, not the treat: something like "I don't mind the treat, I need to know about it."
- ☐ If you're not raising it this time, let it end here for tonight, with no extra comment to your child about Grandma.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Some of the sting may come from Grandma handing out warmth and leeway you never got.
- 2 By three, kids already sort rules by place, no explaining required. They do this without help.
- 3 Whether she'd do it with you standing there is the real test: if she'd only bend it while you're gone, **your kid is stuck holding a secret**.

What this isn't doing to your kid, or to you

KNOW

Some of the sting may come from Grandma handing out warmth and leeway you never got.

Naming that separately keeps a small treat from turning into a much bigger fight than it deserves. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

By three, kids already sort rules by place, no explaining required. They do this without help.

Three-year-olds tested this way protested only when a rule broke in its own spot. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Whether Grandma's rules differing from yours harms your kid has never been shown, not proven.

The researchers who study this exact question flagged it as unexamined in their own results. [Source 2](#)

What's actually driving her leniency

DON'T

Don't take her leniency as a verdict on your parenting; it's rarely about you at all.

She isn't the person stuck disciplining day after day, so being lenient costs her nothing. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

Some of it may be timing, not spite: to her, doing things the way she always did might still feel like the right way to parent.

An old rule of thumb can feel simply correct to her, even when parenting norms have moved on. [Source 4](#)

Reading it right, and what happens if you speak up

WATCH

Whether she'd do it with you standing there is the real test: if she'd only bend it while you're gone, **your kid is stuck holding a secret**.

A grandparent who isn't hiding anything from you isn't asking your child to cover for her. [Source 5](#)

WATCH

Bringing up a broken rule with her can backfire in a specific way: she acts like the wronged party, and you end up comforting her instead of settling anything.

When someone plays the injured party, attention shifts to comforting her rather than to what you raised. [Source 5](#)

DO

Asking her to change something works more often than you'd think.

Among parents who tried it, close to half said the grandparent actually changed what they were doing; another third agreed but didn't follow through. [Source 4](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

If Grandma lets your kid get away with things, your kid learns that working one adult against another is how you get what you want, and every rule gets harder to hold after that.

ACTUALLY

Learning to manipulate people isn't what the evidence actually shows here. **Researchers who study whether differing caregivers cause harm haven't found this**; they've only flagged it as a question nobody has answered yet. A young child sorting out that Grandma's house runs differently is not being taught to work people. [Source 2](#)

Sources

1. https://www.eva.mpg.de/documents/Wiley-Blackwell/Rakoczy_Young_BrJDevPsych_2009_1553047.pdf
2. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10787874/>
3. <https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/evolution-of-the-self/201601/4-key-reasons-grandmas-act-differently-with-their-grandkids>
4. <https://mottpoll.org/reports/when-parents-and-grandparents-disagree>

5. https://www.huffpost.com/entry/grandparents-bending-your-rules-is-mostly-harmless-until-it-becomes-a-secret_l_6a91a9cfe4b0edeb8bbcbfde

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on In-laws and the wider family at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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